

the curriculum. They are also sitting at the heads of foundations, in the agencies of government—and in the newsrooms of powerful newspapers.

The intellectual atmosphere is filled with stifling vapors, and the gas is not just being expelled by Jesse Helms. The National Endowment for the Arts is beginning to penalize those grantees that cannot justify themselves on the basis of minority representation, and most of the private foundations are focusing on "multicultural" programs and audience development. (The Boston Foundation, which has not offered a penny to the arts

in almost a decade, has at last decided to contribute money—to projects displaying "cultural diversity.") This political agenda is being enforced, of course, on behalf of minorities, but there is one minority that's been excluded—the artist, who works on behalf of the imagination, unmindful of color, regardless of race, unused to being told precisely what and how to create. It is unlikely that this superficial approach to racial reconciliation will resolve our social conflicts or advance our minorities. There is no doubt, however, that it will block the flow of free expression in the arts. •

Destiny Is Anatomy

By KATHARINE PARK AND ROBERT A. NYE

Making Sex: Body and Gender from the Greeks to Freud by Thomas Laqueur

(Harvard University Press, 313 pp., \$27.95)

In 1573 Ambroise Paré, surgeon to the king of France, recorded the strange case of a man called Germain Garnier, whom he had observed when the royal entourage passed through the town of Vitry le François. Until the age of 15, Germain, who had been baptized Marie, had lived and dressed as a girl. While chasing pigs one day, she leaped over a ditch, whereupon the ligaments that held her genitals within her snapped, according to Paré, allowing a male penis to appear, and sending her home to her mother in tears. After a committee of local doctors and surgeons pronounced her a man, she took a new name, and eventually grew a red beard.

Paré explained her astonishing metamorphosis in these terms: "The reason women can change into men is because they have hidden inside their bodies that which men carry outside, and they lack only the heat necessary to push out the genitals kept bound within by the coldness of their temperament." By running with her pigs, Marie had elevated her internal heat enough to correct this defect. The reverse transformation, however, could never occur, since "nature always tends toward perfection and does not, on the contrary, act such that the perfect becomes imperfect."

Such an explanation, argues Thomas Laqueur in this provocative new book, would be impossible today. We stand on the other side of a great chasm, a continental divide in thinking about sex, that

separates us from Paré and his predecessors. "Sometime in the eighteenth century," as he puts it, "sex as we know it was invented." Before then, people (by which he means primarily medical writers) acknowledged the existence of only one sex, the male one. Men and women were seen as arranged along a vertical spectrum, corresponding to their degree of vital heat and metaphysical perfection. Their cultural and social world recognized the traditional two genders, but this distinction was insecure and ungrounded, with no basis in contemporary medicine or biology. Physiologically speaking, woman was not the "opposite" sex, but only a degenerate form of man; and her reproductive organs were an inverted version of the male genitals, trapped within her body as Paré described.

It was only after about 1750, Laqueur maintains, that this "one-sex model" gave way to a "two-sex model" based on the idea of a radical dimorphism between men and women. Woman was no longer seen as a "lesser version of man along a vertical axis of infinite gradations, but rather as an altogether different creature along a horizontal axis whose middle ground was largely empty." A primary index of this shift, according to Laqueur, was the disappearance of the female orgasm, which earlier writers considered necessary for procreation. In the years after 1750, this view began to lose its hold. By the mid-nineteenth century, the female orgasm had been ban-

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ished by doctors to the "borderlands of physiology," creating, as if by default, a sexually anesthetized woman—the passionless and respectable housewife—in place of the lusty goodwife of the Renaissance.

Laqueur's book is an ambitious attempt to demonstrate this transformation by examining medical writing over the two-and-a-half millennia between Aristotle and Freud. He uses a wide array of texts and images to reveal how representations of sex and the body, however mutable, are always infused and informed by contemporary assumptions about the proper relations between men and women. The representations thus serve as metaphors for the inequitable social and political order they mean to justify. He offers powerful proof that woman's nature is always culturally "produced" in the absence of decisive scientific facts, and even, occasionally, in the teeth of evidence to the contrary. "Serious talk about sexuality," as he puts it, "is thus inevitably about the social order it both represents and legitimates." That order, like our ideas about sex, has so far been dominated by men. Thus a penis is a penis, but it is also a status symbol, marking its possessor as a member of the group whose physical and metaphysical attributes render them—by their own account—the proper custodians of knowledge and power.

Laqueur's arguments for this larger point are passionate and eloquent, and his evidence is massive and convincing. He is filling in the broad outlines of the interpretation sketched by Foucault in his groundbreaking *History of Sexuality*, and drawing on feminist theory and historiography as elaborated in the work of Joan Scott, Sander Gilman, and Linda Schiebinger. With them, he is helping to transform the field, we would hope permanently: once an anemic and self-congratulatory narrative of scientific discoveries concerning reproductive anatomy and physiology, the history of sexuality is finally being integrated into cultural history as a whole.

But what of Laqueur's specific arguments concerning the one-sex body and the two-sex body and the eighteenth-century shift between them? Here, unfortunately, the evidence is much less convincing. The closer one looks at his chronology, and at the texts and the images that he adduces, the more his distinction between the two models blurs into a haze of contradictions. These problems are most pronounced in the first half of his book, which deals with the period up to the Enlightenment. Here a more complete reading of the sources shows that there never was a one-sex

model in Laqueur's sense—not in Aristotle, not in Galen, not in Paré—although sexual difference was defined somewhat differently than in the nineteenth century. But even Laqueur's account of the later period has serious flaws. Bent on proving his own thesis, often to the extent of seriously distorting the evidence, he undervalues many of the continuities that link the age of Freud with the Renaissance.

For a start, he consistently imposes a false homogeneity on his sources, especially for the long and varied period before 1750. There is, in truth, no single early Western model of sex and sexual difference. Laqueur's "one-sex model" is a hybrid of individual and sometimes mutually contradictory features assembled from the two dominant and fundamentally incompatible traditions of early writing on the subject, the Aristotelian and the Hippocratic/Galenic. From Aristotle, Laqueur takes the notion of woman as an imperfect man, characterized by a lower degree of vital (or more properly, complexional) heat. From Galen, he takes the ideas that female genitals are inverted versions of the male, and that orgasm is indispensable for a woman to emit her seed and thus to conceive. But he downplays a countervailing Aristotelian thesis, which is that the female contributes no seed and therefore requires no orgasm.

Aristotle, in fact, together with the Aristotelian theorists who dominated European thinking on sexuality between 1250 and 1550, expounded a two-sex model more sharply delineated in many respects than any modern theory. For these writers, women's sexual function was in no way parallel to men's. Women were essentially incubators; they provided a place for the fetus to develop and the matter to nourish it, while male semen contributed the formal principle, or soul. Thus women could become pregnant without orgasm and without knowledge. As Danielle Jacquart and Claude Thomasset have put it (in *Sexuality and Medicine in the Middle Ages*, the best single antidote to Laqueur's reading of the early period), woman "is thus the perfect antithesis of the male, who acts on this unconscious mechanism in a responsible and conscious way."

Laqueur's textual and pictorial evidence concerning the supposed identity of the male and female genitals is fascinating, but it, too, is ultimately unconvincing. His use of the early sixteenth-century anatomist Berengario da Carpi is typical of the kinds of partial readings on which his interpretation is based. Citing Berengario's own words that "the vagina is like the penis and the womb with testi-

cles and vessels is like the scrotum" (our emphasis), Laqueur glosses them to mean that "the vagina really is a penis, and the uterus is a scrotum"—a conclusion that would certainly have puzzled Berengario and his contemporaries. Similarly, Laqueur claims repeatedly that before the eighteenth century the female reproductive organs were referred to only by the names of their male analogues, yet he himself refers to a passage in which Berengario calls the foreskin by the standard Latin word for the female labia, and he reproduces a woodcut from Berengario's anatomy that identifies the scrotum as an "inverted womb."

The argument that it was only in the eighteenth century that medical theorists began to conceive of a two-sex model is simply false. Later writers did indeed conceive of men and women as bimodally distributed along an axis of sexual difference, but so did medical theorists from the Greeks to the Renaissance—though Laqueur is right to emphasize the language of perfection and the vertical character of the axis in that period. With respect to the "middle ground" of the spectrum, there was some disagreement. Asserting the incommensurability of male and female, Aristotelians tended to claim that it was necessarily and absolutely empty; perfect hermaphroditism was impossible, and sex changes like Germain Garnier's were only apparent. Anti-Aristotelians such as Paré, writing in the full flush of the French Hippocratic revival of the mid-sixteenth century, held that such cases were theoretically possible, if extremely rare. We can find more typical contemporary reactions, even in France, among the (fictional) interlocutors of Guillaume Bouchet's *Serées* (1584), who greeted the story of Germain Garnier with great skepticism, and the (real) participants in the meeting of the Parisian Bureau d'Adresse in 1636, one of whom denied any possibility of a perfect hermaphrodite with the following words: "Because the internal and fundamental principal . . . of man is opposed to that of woman, because one consists in activity and the other in passivity, one in giving and the other in receiving, they can never coexist in the same individual."

The problem is that Laqueur seems unwilling to accept that the metaphysical categories and distinctions of classical and Renaissance writers were just as real to them as our more material ones are to us. He insists on collapsing their rich world of analogies into notions of identity, in keeping with our modern outlook. Many early medical theorists, like the poets and the philosophers of their time, saw the moral and physical universe as a

dense web of correspondences linking not only the male and female genitals, but also the realms of animal, vegetable, and mineral. Each statement of analogy contained within it a dynamic tension, a simultaneous affirmation of similarity and (just as important) of difference. While the similarities lent unity to the universe, the differences assured its variety and acted as signs of God's infinite creativity. Any reading that emphasizes only the similarities in this cosmos, let alone reduces them to identities, misrepresents the entire structure.

Laqueur's myopia is ironic: he proposes a sophisticated critique of nineteenth-century biologism, but he cannot acknowledge as real any early medical concept of sexual difference not exclusively grounded in anatomy and the material world. He knows that medieval and Renaissance natural philosophers regarded the differences between the sexes in the first instance as metaphysical—perfect vs. imperfect, formal vs. material, active vs. passive—but he fails to see that such metaphysical distinctions had an ontological status for them that gave rise to palpable physical differences. He can accept these metaphysical differences only as "sociological," "rhetorical," or "political" projections, and so he can make sense of them only by assimilating them to the modern concept of gender. Thus he maintains that Renaissance writers recognized "at least two genders" (a sociological category), but only one sex (an anatomical one). This distinction may make sense to us, but it would have been incomprehensible to premodern philosophers and doctors.

The same totalizing impulse bedevils Laqueur's account of European thinking about sexuality after 1750, when, he argues, "sex" began to divide male from female in the way that "gender" did before. This era of liberal revolution ironically accompanied a revolution in medical thinking that deprived women of both their political rights and their orgasms, relegating them even more definitively than before to the private and domestic sphere of family and children.

Here Laqueur offers powerful evidence that woman's nature continued to be culturally produced, even against the grain of evidence. In the late eighteenth century, medical writers focused increasingly on the "economy" of female reproductive processes, allowing middle-class doctors to conclude that women's delicate child-bearing function had to be shielded from the hurly-burly of work and public life. By the 1840s they had renamed the ovaries (female testes, in the old medicine) and decided, many

decades before their role in hormonal regulation was even suspected, that they were somehow what made a woman a woman. They used this "knowledge" to justify the widespread practice of ovariectomies, which were intended to treat hysteria or inappropriate sexual behavior.

In Laqueur's view, however, the most egregious casualty of this new way of thinking was the female orgasm, banished in order to undergird the concept of woman as "angel in the house." He shows convincingly that many nineteenth-century doctors, although they knew as little about ovulation as their Renaissance counterparts, nonetheless concluded, with much tortured reasoning,

that women could have the requisite fertilizing orgasm without feeling it at all.

On this point, however, as in many of his other assertions, Laqueur's claims are open to dispute, as he himself occasionally notes. Carl Degler, Peter Gay, and others have pointed to the many memoirs and letters testifying to the orgasmic capacities of nineteenth-century women and the considerable body of medical opinion that acknowledged it. If one part of the medical profession was eager to anesthetize women, a host of sexual advice manuals advocated the delights of connubial bliss, and warned how easily physical love might founder on the shoals of male indifference or brutality.



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Alan Wolfe is the Michael E. Gellert Professor of Sociology and Political Science and Dean of The Graduate Faculty.

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Nineteenth-century embryologists, moreover, perpetuated the old Galenic notion of genital homologies by demonstrating that male and female genitalia developed out of the same anatomical structure, while other researchers rejected late eighteenth-century convictions about the universality of sexual reproduction, calling attention to budding, hermaphroditism, and other forms of reproductive parthenogenesis. In the same way, Isidore Geoffroy Saint-Hilaire's highly influential *Treatise on Teratology* (1832-37) explored the middle of the supposedly dichotomous sexual spectrum and reported it populated by a variety of "effeminate" men and "masculine" women marked by a continuum of genital abnormalities. A large clitoris was an "arrested penis" and a small penis a "hypertrophied clitoris," and both inclined their bearers away from the "type" of their sex.

Though nineteenth-century doctors denied, like Aristotle and his followers, the theoretical possibility of true human hermaphroditism, in practice the medical literature is replete with examples of ambiguous sexual identity. One of the most famous cases was that of Hercule Barbin, raised as a female, who worked as a governess and later as a teacher. According to the memoirs found after his suicide in 1868, Barbin fell ill and was examined by a doctor, who discovered testicles imbedded on either side of a shallow cul-de-sac that appeared for all the world to be a vagina, together with a rudimentary imperforate penis that could pass for a "voluminous" clitoris. Forced to change his civil status, Barbin lived the rest of his brief and unhappy life in a state of sexual indecision, suspended between his internal sense of female identity and his male persona. Although the experts cited his testicles as the deciding factor, the reasons that obliged them to decide at all were more legal than anatomical. According to Saint-Hilaire, there can be no sexual intermediaries, not because such do not exist in nature but because "our laws do not admit their existence or foresee their possibility."

But there is a deeper problem inherent in Laqueur's work than the implausibility of his one-sex, two-sex thesis, and it is owed to his admirable feminist commitments. In presenting the history of scientific research on sex as an attempt to justify a male-dominated social order, he ignores the extent to which many men, particularly homosexual men, fell afoul of the same theories, as Saint-Hilaire's remarks on effeminate men make clear. According to Laqueur, male scientists have always constructed the signs of sexual difference on wom-

en's "unstable" bodies. Taking their own bodies as the norm, they have projected ideas of imperfection or opposition onto female anatomy and physiology, rendering the male body transparent and a "history of man's body and its pleasures" probably impossible. By excluding men from his interpretation in this way, Laqueur not only flies in the face of the evidence, but also undermines his own praiseworthy effort to demonstrate the scope of the cultural construction of sexuality. From this point of view, his intellectual enterprise, far from being too ambitious, is not ambitious enough: like women's bodies, men's bodies also need to be liberated from the constraints of phallogocentric science.

This loss of nerve accounts for what is certainly the most surprising aspect of Laqueur's description of the one-sex model: his claim that before the middle of the eighteenth century (and before the invention of woman as different from man), homoeroticism could not be seen as a violation of the natural heterosexual order, but only as a "culturally unacceptable reversal of power and prestige." Laqueur is right here, as elsewhere, to emphasize the latter: in sixteenth-century France and Spain, for example, only lesbians who usurped the male role by using a dildo received death sentences. But his interpretation forces him to ignore the vast body of theological, legal, and medical theory in the high Middle Ages and Renaissance that set procreative, heterosexual sex at the heart of the natural universe and associated sodomy with heresy, as a rejection of the physical and metaphysical order created by God. For this reason, both merited the unique penalty of burning at the stake.

In this area, as in many others, the continuities between Renaissance and nineteenth-century ideas are as striking as the contrasts. If medieval Aristotelians denied the existence of intermediate points between male and female on the sexual spectrum, many Renaissance writers (particularly those influenced by Hippocratic ideas) subscribed to the same vision as Saint-Hilaire. Men who exhausted their sexual resources or behaved in an effeminate way could slide toward the female end of the spectrum, and conversely for women. After the middle of the sixteenth century, these behaviorally and anatomically deviant types were increasingly identified with homosexuals, particularly male homosexuals, and eventually subjected to all the scorn that the medical establishment could heap upon them.

A few sympathetic doctors attempted heroic intervention. A French physician writing in the mid-nineteenth century,

for example, tells us of a young medical student unable to maintain an erection during intercourse. The student had "Lilliputian" genitals, was effeminate, and spoke in an unusually high voice. Moved by his plight, the doctor fitted him with an ingeniously designed prosthesis that allowed him to feel during coitus the frictions that his organ was too small to provoke, and he prescribed as much sex "as his delicate constitution would bear," together with solid nourishment and light physical activity. After some time on this regime, the doctor was pleased to report, the patient's penis had increased perceptibly in size. As these examples suggest, men's bodies are also unstable. Men have historically held themselves to ideals of masculinity as unrealistic and coercive as anything they have imposed on women.

In the same vein, Laqueur's sensitivity to medical misogyny leads him to interpret the punitive literature concerning masturbation as primarily an assault on women, and to present Freud only as the perpetrator of a scheme to displace women's clitoral orgasms to their vaginas. But the medical devices for inhibiting masturbation in boys, while stopping short of castration—girls might receive clitorectomies—were notoriously brutal; and Freud, for all his enlightenment about homosexuality, spent his whole clinical life trying to "cure" unhappy inverts. The misogyny that underlies Western medical writing on sexuality is indeed staggering, and Laqueur has documented it with sympathy and passion, but this should not blind us to other forms of sexual intolerance, most notably the homophobia with which it was so frequently associated.

It is a further irony that Laqueur's sincere attempt to offer a feminist interpretation of his material ends up by obliterating not only homophobia from large portions of his narrative, but ultimately women themselves. His presentation of the one-sex model in particular assumes a patriarchy so hegemonic that even women speak with a male voice. One puts down the book with the distinct impression that women have been expunged from 2,300 years of medical writing about sex, surviving only in the ghostly forms of male ideological constructs. Laqueur's celebration of the pre-modern period as a time of somehow greater sexual indeterminacy and freedom reads in some respects like a male fantasy of a womanless world.

Still, there is a good deal to be learned from this well-meaning and occasionally brilliant book. Laqueur's analyses of particular problems and issues within the history of ideas on sex are often percep-

tive and convincing—for example, his description of the Aristotelian account of conception as an attempt to ground paternity metaphysically in the absence of any clear physical link between father and child, or his discussion of nineteenth-century language that anthropomorphized the egg and sperm. He rightly calls attention to a marked decline in emphasis on female pleasure and desire over the period between 1600 and 1900, and to the ways in which that decline reflected the creation of a new (if equally procrustean) feminine ideal. And there is no doubt that the same period saw a dramatic, if gradual, transformation in thinking about sex and sex difference, rooted in a biologicistic and medicalizing terminology that slowly supplanted the earlier metaphysical language. It is a transformation that has affected all our lives.

But it is important to know more than Laqueur tells us about why this happened, and about the context for these textual shifts. One part of that story belongs to the broader history of philosophy and religion, and reflects the gradual death of metaphysics in favor of an aggressive scientism that is still much with us. Another part belongs to political and social history, as Laqueur occasionally suggests. During the period in question, the public realm of political decision expanded dramatically in size, from narrow societies of kings and courtiers to national polities including middle-class men exercising their newly minted natural rights. Laqueur rightly indicates that the biological disfranchisement of women from this new public sphere was linked somehow to the natural rights

claims of liberal and democratic political theory. Further research might tell us how definitions of legal capacity in civil and criminal law, new formulations of property rights and inheritance, and new conceptions of citizenship were related to the tendency to think about sexual difference in materialistic and anatomical terms, and thus to make the differences between men and women as great as the modern imagination and its new scientific lexicon would allow.

None of this means, however, that the gulf between the sexes was somehow greater or more unbridgeable after 1750 than before. Sex difference was as crucial a part of premodern mentality as it is of our own, though each historical epoch expressed this difference in language appropriate to its own cosmology. We find our hopes for a better, more tolerant, and more equitable world in different places. Laqueur projects his own hopes into the past, where he imagines men and women were somehow less constrained than they are now in shaping their sexual identities and expressing their sexual desires. Yet his book inspires a slightly different hope, to understand more completely how and why sex continues to be constructed in ways that perpetuate patriarchy and homophobia.

KATHARINE PARK is the William R. Kenan Jr. Professor at Wellesley College and the author of *Doctors and Medicine in Early Renaissance Florence* (Princeton University Press). ROBERT A. NYE is professor of history at the University of Oklahoma. His new book, *Masculinity and Male Codes of Honor in Modern France*, will be published by Oxford University Press.

Beyond Sentimentalism

By CHRISTOPHER LASCH

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